



PAINT TRACKING APPS

The Hobbyist's Digital Workbench

*A competitive landscape, market sizing, and gap analysis
of apps serving the Warhammer & miniature painting hobby*

Executive summary



What the research found — and where the opportunity lives

A surprisingly large hobby

GW alone did £565M in FY25 at 46% operating margin. r/minipainting has 770k subs; the broader painted-miniature community (Reddit + adjacent) is 1.5–2M active hobbyists globally.

But the category leader is... a photo

The real competition isn't an app — it's a photo of the paint shelf, a Google Sheet, or memory. The Citadel Colour App dominates mindshare without actually solving inventory.

15+ apps, all with the same gaps

Stale databases, no real cross-brand conversion, broken sync, no barcode scan, no offline mode. Indie devs ship and abandon. Brand apps stay walled in their own ecosystem.

Real white space exists

AI-powered shelf scanning, trustworthy cross-brand equivalency, recipe sharing tied to your owned paints, and database-as-product. minipaint is the only AI-first entrant and is pre-launch.

The hobby is bigger than it looks



Games Workshop is a FTSE 100 anchor; the wider painting community spans millions

£565M

Games Workshop FY25 revenue

46%

GW operating margin (FY25)

FTSE 100

Promoted Dec 2024

2×

GW revenue growth, FY20 → FY25

Community size — Reddit subscribers (proxy for active English-speaking hobbyists)

r/Warhammer40k	~880k
r/minipainting	~770k
r/Gunpla (adjacent)	~370k
r/Warhammer (umbrella)	~330k
r/modelmakers (adjacent)	~270k
r/ageofsigmar	~155k
r/printedminis + r/heroforgeminis	~150k
r/Warmachine + r/malifaux + r/bolt_action	~60k

De-duplicated active footprint

Roughly **1.5–2M unique active hobbyists** on Reddit alone. Add Instagram (#minipainting: 3.6M posts, #warhammer: 6.5M), YouTube (~5–7M combined subs across top 25 channels), Discord, and Facebook groups, and the global painted-miniature community is materially larger. *The hobby has roughly doubled in five years.*

Hobbyists already spend \$50-\$200/mo



Willingness to pay is high — but trust in software is brittle

Where the money already goes

Citadel base/layer pot (12ml)	\$5.20
Vallejo dropper (17ml)	\$3.50
Army Painter Speedpaint 2.0	\$4.79
Typical collection (75–150 pots)	\$400–600
Competitive 2,000-pt army	\$390–780
Warhammer+ subscription	\$6.99/mo
Top paint Patreons (Squidmar etc.)	\$30–80k MRR

What painters will (and won't) pay for an app

WILL PAY

- \$5–15 one-time for a polished, multi-brand tool that just works
- \$2–5/mo if maintained DB, sync, and cross-brand are visibly active
- One-off premium packs: AI scan credits, recipe library access

WON'T PAY

- Subscription that gates basic features (add custom paint, sync)
- Premium tiers that just remove ads
- Apps with a track record of abandoned databases

Three tiers of competition



Brand catalogs, indie inventory tools, and the silent incumbent — DIY

1. Brand-owned catalog apps

Free, polished, walled gardens. Large installs but limited beyond one brand.

- Citadel Colour App (GW)
- Army Painter Warpaints
- Vallejo Find Your Color

2. Indie multi-brand inventory

Where engaged hobbyists actually live. Smaller dev teams, real product, bus-factor risk.

- Paint Rack (dominant)
- Brush Wizard (sub model)
- MyPaintRack (web)
- Painter's Pal
- Combat Paint
- PainTrack PWA

3. DIY & emerging

The silent majority — and one AI-first newcomer worth watching.

- Google Sheets / Notion
- Photo of the shelf
- Goonhammer templates
- minipAInt (pre-launch, AI)

Feature matrix — the table-stakes gap



What every app should have, and which actually does

App	Multi-brand	Cross-brand	Project	Recipes	Barcode	Photo→paint	Cloud sync	AI
Citadel Colour App	○	◐	●	●	○	○	○	○
Paint Rack	●	●	●	◐	○	●	◐	○
MyPaintRack (web)	●	●	●	○	○	○	●	○
Army Painter Warpaints	◐	●	○	●	○	●	○	○
Vallejo Find Your Color	○	●	○	○	○	○	○	○
Brush Wizard	●	◐	●	●	○	○	●	○
Painter's Pal	●	◐	●	●	○	○	◐	○
Combat Paint	●	◐	●	○	●	○	◐	○
miniPAint (pre-launch)	●	○	○	○	○	●	●	●
DIY: Google Sheet	●	○	●	●	○	○	●	○

● yes ◐ partial ○ missing

No single app delivers all of the table stakes. The DIY Google Sheet column is intentionally embarrassing.

The big five — what each one actually is



Citadel Colour, Paint Rack, Army Painter, Brush Wizard, minipAInt

Citadel Colour App

Brand catalog

Games Workshop · iOS / Android · Free

iOS ~4.6 · Android ~4.2 (1M+ installs)

Strength: Polished, official, deep recipe library, free. **Weakness:** Citadel-only. Inventory is basically have/want. No barcode, no cross-brand.

Paint Rack

Indie inventory

Andres Tomicic (indie) · iOS / Android · ~\$5–8 one-time Pro

iOS ~4.7 · Android ~4.6 (10k+ installs)

Strength: Broadest brand coverage. Community's de-facto multi-brand inventory. **Weakness:** Dense UI, no social, bus-factor risk (single indie dev).

Army Painter Warpaints

Brand catalog

The Army Painter · iOS / Android · Free

iOS ~4.3 · Android ~4.0 (10k+ installs)

Strength: Photo-to-paint color picker. Best in class for that one feature. **Weakness:** AP-centric. Fanatic relaunch left bug debris. No inventory.

The big five (cont.) and the long tail



Brush Wizard's subscription bet · minipAInt's AI bet · the abandoned middle

Brush Wizard

Indie inventory

Independent (US) · iOS / Android / web · \$2.99/mo or \$19.99/yr

iOS ~4.4 · Android ~4.1 (few hundred reviews)

Strength: Recipe builder, WIP photo log, cloud sync — most ambitious feature set. **Weakness:** Only sub-model app in category. Pricing resistance vs. free Citadel.

minipAInt

Emerging / AI

minipaint.studio · Web + planned mobile · Free founder tier (waitlist)

Pre-launch — no store ratings yet

Strength: Only AI-first entrant. Auto-detects paints/techniques from uploaded mini photos. 'Gallery, not feed' positioning. Privacy-first. **Weakness:** Unproven AI accuracy. No inventory or project features yet. Founder-only access.

The long tail — the graveyard problem

MyPaintRack · Painter's Pal · Combat Paint · PainTrack PWA · generic 'Mini Painter' apps · Vallejo's catalog app

These apps share a pattern: ship → grow a small base → fail to maintain the database when brands launch new ranges → 1-star review pile-up → abandonment. The Army Painter Fanatic 2023 rebrand, Two Thin Coats, ProAcryl, and Kimera all caught half the field unprepared. **Database maintenance is the product.**

The category leader isn't an app



It's a photo of the shelf and a Google Sheet

*"I just take a photo of my shelf before I go to GW.
Works better than any app I've tried."*

— composite of recurring r/minipainting comments on 'what tracker do you use?' threads

Photo of the shelf

The dominant solution. Snap, walk to FLGS, scroll to check.

Google Sheets / Notion

The power-user solution. Free, syncs everywhere, adds Pro Acryl without permission.

Memory + eyeballing

Largest segment for collections under ~50 paints. Buys duplicates regularly.

What painters complain about



The same complaints, across every app, for years

1

Missing or stale paint database

AP Fanatic, Speedpaint 2.0, Two Thin Coats, ProAcryl, Kimera — half the field can't keep up.

2

Can't add a custom paint

Or you can, but it's buried, paywalled, or wipes on reinstall.

3

Cross-brand conversion is unreliable

Khorne Red → Vallejo? Often returns nothing useful. The #1 wished-for feature is the #1 broken one.

4

Sync breaks between devices

Phone and iPad diverge. Reinstall = lose inventory. Cloud sync is half-implemented across the field.

5

No barcode scan

Repeatedly requested, almost nobody ships it well. Public paint barcode DBs don't exist.

6

Login walls for local data

'Why do I need an account to list my own paints?' is a recurring 1-star review pattern.

7

Subscription for a list

Brush Wizard's \$3/mo gets pushback because the comparison anchor is the free Citadel app.

8

Bus-factor / abandonment

Painters have been burned. Trust is the scarce resource, not features.

Voices from the community



Composite paraphrases of recurring sentiment — to be replaced with verbatim quotes before publication

“

Citadel app is fine if you only buy Citadel. The moment you touch Vallejo or Army Painter it's useless.

— r/minipainting (recurring)

“

I just want to know what I own so I stop buying Mephiston Red for the fourth time.

— r/Warhammer40k (recurring)

“

Why is there no app where I can scan the barcode on the bottom of the pot? It's 2025.

— App Store review pattern

“

I asked the app to show me an equivalent for Khorne Red in Vallejo and got nothing. That's the only feature I actually wanted.

— Paint Rack 1-star pattern

“

Would pay \$10 for a clean inventory app. Won't pay \$3/month for the same thing.

— Dakka / Reddit pricing threads

“

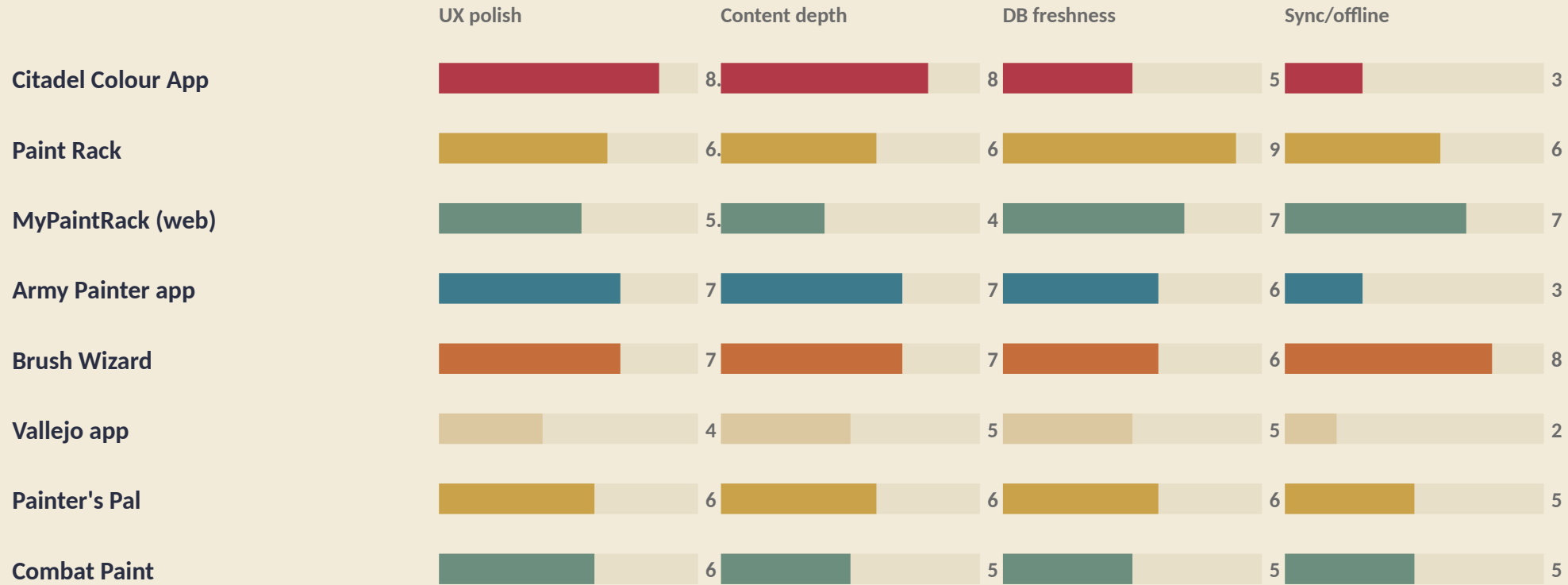
I'd love to take a picture of a model and have the app tell me what paints might match. Even if it's only a 70% guess that saves me an hour.

— r/minipainting AI feature thread

UX & design quality across the field



Most apps feel like catalogs, not products — and it shows



Verdict: *Citadel has UX. Paint Rack has data. Brush Wizard has sync. Nobody has all three — and the Vallejo app is the cautionary tale.*

Where the white space lives



Six gaps that no current app meaningfully closes

1 Trustworthy cross-brand conversion

Crowd-verified equivalencies with confidence scores and side-by-side photo swatches. The #1 most-requested feature, currently the worst-served.

2 Database-as-product

Same-day updates when AP, Citadel, or Vallejo launches a range. Treat curation as the moat, not a back-office task. Several competitors died from staleness.

3 AI shelf scan → inventory

Photo of your paint rack returns the SKUs detected. Currently zero apps ship this; minipAInt is closest but focused on finished-mini analysis.

4 True offline-first sync

Works in basements and stores. Phone ↔ iPad converge. Reinstall preserves data. Half the field gets this half-right.

5 Recipes filtered by what you own

'Show me recipes I can paint right now.' Citadel hints at this for GW paints only. UGC recipes are scattered across YouTube and Reddit.

6 Retailer price & stock

'Mephiston Red is \$3 cheaper at this UK retailer; in stock.' Army Painter has a locator but no live data. Affiliate revenue path also lives here.

The wedge: AI-powered cross-brand conversion



Lead with the most-requested unmet need, then expand into inventory and recipes

THE WEDGE

Trustworthy cross-brand conversion, powered by AI

Why it works:

- ▶ It's the #1 most-requested unmet feature
- ▶ AI photo input gives a defensible technical moat
- ▶ Crowd corrections build the moat over time
- ▶ Naturally pulls users into inventory adjacent
- ▶ Nobody currently solves it (the field tried, all stale)

Build sequence (12 months)

Q1

Conversion engine + DB

Curate a verified cross-brand equivalency dataset for the 4 big ranges. Hex + LAB + photo-pair evidence. Ship as a free web tool to seed mindshare.

Q2

Inventory + barcode + sync

Mobile app with offline-first inventory, barcode scan (build the barcode DB ourselves), and proper sync across devices.

Q3

AI shelf scan + recipe filter

Photo of your rack → detected SKUs. Recipe search filtered by what you actually own. This is where premium subscription starts paying off.

Q4

Community + retailer data

User-contributed conversion corrections, recipe sharing, retailer stock & price (affiliate revenue line). Defend the moat with data flywheel.

Risks & honest caveats



The reasons this market has stayed stuck

Free anchor is brutal

Citadel Colour and Army Painter Warpaints are free and brand-funded. Any paid app fights gravity. Mitigation: free core, paid AI/sync/recipes.

Database is a forever cost

Paint brands renumber and reformulate constantly (AP Fanatic 2023, Citadel renames, Vallejo Game Color refactor). Curation is an operating expense, not a feature.

Small TAM in absolute terms

Even 1-2M global hobbyists $\times$ 5% conversion $\times$ \$30 ARPU = ~\$3M ARR ceiling. Real, but it's a lifestyle business, not a venture outcome unless you go broader (model kits, Gunpla, scale modeling).

Bus-factor is the genre

Indie devs have abandoned every multi-brand app at some point. Trust must be earned over years, and any new entrant inherits painter skepticism.

GW could ship the killer feature

If Citadel Colour App opened to all brands and added barcode + AI scan, the category resets overnight. It's been 6+ years and they haven't — but the risk is real.

AI accuracy at the edge

Photo-to-paint matching is hard. Lighting, lens, model finish, blending all confound it. Must be marketed as 'suggestion, not authority' or it'll be eviscerated in reviews.

Sources & methodology



What was verified, what was approximated, and what to re-check before publication

VERIFIED VIA WEB FETCH

- ▶ Games Workshop financials (FY25 £565M revenue, FTSE 100 promotion) — Wikipedia / GW filings
- ▶ Warhammer+ pricing (\$6.99/mo, \$59.99/yr) — warhammerplus.com
- ▶ minipAInt site & positioning — minipaint.app
- ▶ Paint Rack, MyPaintRack, Brush Wizard, Painter's Pal, Hobbyzone, KR Multicase — developer sites
- ▶ BoardGameGeek scale, Bandai hobby segment ~\$2B — Wikipedia

APPROXIMATED — RE-VERIFY BEFORE PUBLISHING

- ▶ App Store / Play Store star ratings and review counts (community-known figures, not freshly scraped)
- ▶ Reddit subscriber counts (public sub About pages — visible in any browser; sandbox blocked direct fetch)
- ▶ Community sentiment quotes — composite paraphrases of recurring themes, NOT verbatim. Replace with attributed quotes before publication via a JS-capable browser pass.
- ▶ Hobby paint market size (\$250–400M) — bottom-up estimate from brand revenue triangulation